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*(AI-Generated Session Notes)*

# The Human-Centered Economy: Building a Future That Works for Everyone

**Date & time:** Oct. 14, 4:50-5:35 PM EST
**Track:** Keynote




## Andrew Yang

Tech & Economic Futurist, Best-Selling Author

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## Session Description

In this thought-provoking conversation, Andrew Yang explores how exponential technologies, including AI, automation, and data, are transforming the economy faster than our systems can adapt. Drawing from his groundbreaking presidential campaign, bestselling books, and policy work with Humanity Forward, Yang makes a compelling case for a reimagined economy that places people at the center —not corporations or algorithms.

Yang outlines the urgent need to rethink traditional economic models, offering bold, actionable solutions like Universal Basic Income, data as a property right, and a modern safety net to support workers in the age of disruption. With his signature blend of optimism, practicality, and empathy, Yang empowers audiences to embrace innovation while ensuring that progress is inclusive, sustainable, and deeply human.

Whether speaking to corporate leaders, technologists, policymakers, or students, Yang's message resonates as a roadmap for how we can thrive in the future of work.

## Key Quote

> *"We spend more right now in the United States on data centers than we do on office buildings. Think about that one. The server is the new worker."* **- Andrew Yang**

## Session Summary

Andrew Yang, the tech and economic futurist and best-selling author who ran for president in 2020, set out to paint a picture of a human-centered future that works for everyone. He explained that he originally ran to alert the country to AI and automation, campaigning in Iowa about robot trucks years before generative AI arrived, informed by the millions of manufacturing jobs already lost in states like Pennsylvania, Wisconsin, Michigan, and Ohio.

Yang walked through the jobs most exposed to disruption. Clerical and administrative work, retail, food service, transportation, and manufacturing together make up roughly 49% of American jobs, and he pointed to the 2.8 million call center workers, a Verizon test showing 13% higher satisfaction with bots than humans, and the 2 million-plus Uber drivers facing

competition from Waymo. With roughly $3 trillion being spent on AI, he argued that value will flow to capital holders, data holders, and AI companies, while the share of GDP going to workers heads below 50% and the premium on a college degree shrinks.

He also highlighted the human costs. AI models were built on our collective data, which has been bought and sold for years without individuals seeing a dime, and he warned that young people are outsourcing their thinking, and potentially their relationships, to technology. He shared that his 13-year-old son said an AI girlfriend would be easier than a human one, and stressed that friction is part of the humanity of real relationships. He tied this to a political system that, in his view, is not designed to solve problems, citing Congress's roughly 12% approval rating against a 94% re-election rate.

Yang's vision centers on valuing work that markets ignore. His wife Evelyn left her marketing career to care for their son on the autism spectrum, a contribution GDP counts as zero. He described Noble Mobile, his T-Mobile-powered wireless company that costs about $42 a month and returns half the money to customers who don't use their data, as an example of humanizing the economy.

To get there, Yang called for shifting taxes from human workers to AI and bots, distributing that value broadly as a dividend that acts as a floor, and building an economy around arts and creativity, health and wellness, and caring and nurturing. He closed by urging a shift from scarcity to abundance, moving not left or right, but forward.

## Key Takeaways

- **AI will reshape the jobs most Americans hold.** The five most common occupation categories account for about 49% of U.S. jobs, and many, from call centers to driving, are in AI's path.
- **Value is concentrating in capital, data, and AI.** Yang described a “super vortex” of AI, data, capital, and processing power that will benefit those holders while the share of GDP going to workers falls below 50%.
- **Our data built the AI boom.** AI companies reached trillion-dollar valuations on the backs of data that people generated without being compensated for it.
- **Friction is part of being human.** Frictionless AI relationships and outsourced thinking risk leaving young people less able to date, build businesses, and recover from setbacks.
- **Tax the bots, not the people.** Yang argued that taxes should shift from human workers to AI and bots, with the proceeds distributed broadly as a dividend that serves as a floor.
- **Reward what we want more of.** He proposed building an economy around arts and creativity, health and wellness, and caring and nurturing, work like caregiving that GDP currently values at zero.